

Raising a RED FLAG

Given their history of reneging on deals, the ceasefire offer by the Maoists is not likely to lull the Centre into going soft



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There is an ominous ring to P. Chidambaram's words when he says that "the Maoists will continue their carnage" and asks citizens to be prepared for a messy and long-drawn battle till the Centre's policy begins to show results. And that may take as long as another three years. But the Union home minister has at least shown that he has the stomach to lead a prolonged fight.

Over the years, crucial time has been frittered away as successive governments lived in a state of denial, refusing to acknowledge that Left-wing extremism was a threat. The Governments' stand largely remained soft and non-confrontational. Now, along with Operation Green Hunt taking the Maoists head-on, the Home Ministry is also fighting a psychological war to crush the image of the

romanticised Naxal. Instead of showing them as people fighting for tribals and the poor against the tyranny of the state, the Government wants the sympathisers to see Naxals for what they are—perpetrators of senseless violence against innocent people.

It is an uphill task by any standard. According to the latest intelligence inputs, these rebels have spread their operations to over 220 districts, covering 92,000 sq km, or over 40 per cent of the country's area. Seven states—Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Bihar, West Bengal, Orissa and Andhra Pradesh are among the worst affected. The Naxal menace has spread to several other states, including Karnataka, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, going right up to the Nepal border and making the so-called Red Corridor bigger, wider and deadlier. The latest attack by the Maoists on the Silda police camp in West Bengal, that left 24 personnel

dead, was their way of cocking a snook at the security forces. The message was loud and clear: they could attack at will and expose chinks in the security armour. The attack, however, has put both the Centre and Maoists under pressure to come to the negotiating table. The bloodbath has to stop.

Chidambaram's message to the Maoists—give up violence for 72 hours and the Government will find a way of opening a dialogue—has started a near farcical back and forth between them. Both have exchanged numbers through the media with no signs of a dialogue opening up. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) believes that the Maoist offer, in addition to being conditional, is not a serious one. "The Maoists, after their recent attack, have received a lot of flak from their usual sympathisers. The offer to stop violence for 72 days and the call for talks is only to deflect pressure and create confusion," says a senior MHA

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